medium and intermediate range missiles and sites in Cuba? Yes or no – don't wait for the translation – yes or no?'[5]

Ambassador Zorin had been as unaware as Ambassador Dobrynin of the missiles in Cuba, and like his colleague in Washington, had yet to receive instructions on how to respond. He replied: 'I am not in an American courtroom, sir, and therefore I do not wish to answer a question that is put to me in the fashion in which a prosecutor does. In due course, sir, you will have your reply. Do not worry.'

Stevenson riposted that Zorin was in the courtroom of world opinion and went on to deliver the famous punchline: 'I'm prepared to wait for my answer until hell freezes over, if that is your decision.' Stevenson's televised confrontation with Zorin became a legendary moment in the crisis. The ambassador gained great kudos for his performance and cemented his image in the history books. 'I never knew he had it in him,' remarked Kennedy.[6]

More significant was the photographic evidence of the Soviet missile bases that Stevenson presented. It is an axiom that intelligence services do not disclose their sources and methods. Privately, the US had shared U-2 images with its closest NATO allies. Public disclosure, however, was unprecedented. McNamara explained to the Pentagon press corps that the photographs could not be released on grounds of national security – unfortunately for the defence secretary, this came as a breakdown in communication between London and Washington meant they were being released to the British media.[7]

Stevenson introduced the Security Council (and the global television audience) to the photographs, displayed on large boards for all to see. The ambassador had, of course, been here before. In April 1961 he produced photographic evidence of a B-26 bomber designed to further CIA deception over the Bay of Pigs, only to discover that he (like Dobrynin and Zorin) was part of a deception. Yet, despite doubts in some quarters about the authenticity of the evidence, there was widespread acceptance of the photography, even though accurate interpretation required the expertise of seasoned photo-analysts. As Sherman Kent remarked: 'of the millions of people of many nations who saw the pictures that fourth week of October,